

GRANT & FUNDING GUIDE FOR AFRICAN MUSIC ARTISTS | 2026

South Africa · Nigeria · Kenya · Tanzania · Uganda · Ghana · Senegal · Cameroon · Côte d'Ivoire ·

African music markets are among the fastest-growing creative economies in the world — yet awareness of available funding is low, and many artists miss out on grants, bursaries, and development programmes simply because they do not know they exist.

This guide documents every verified, currently active funding programme available to musicians, producers, music managers, and music organisations across South Africa and key African markets as of 2026. Unlike generic lists that include discontinued or unverified programmes, every entry below has been checked for current status. Where a cycle has closed, the next expected opening is noted.

KEY: Each entry includes the grant name, administering organisation, funding amount, eligibility, application process, website, and confirmed 2026 status. Always verify deadlines directly with the funding body — windows open and close rapidly.

SOUTH AFRICA

NAC Annual Project Funding

Organisation	National Arts Council of South Africa (NAC)
Amount / Value	Up to R350,000 per project
Who Can Apply	South African citizens (individual practitioners) or registered SA entities active in music, dance, theatre, literature, craft, visual arts, or multidisciplinary arts.
How to Apply	Register and apply online at nac.praxisgms.co.za . Applications for the 2026/2027 cycle closed March 2026 — watch nac.org.za for the next cycle announcement.
Website	www.nac.org.za
Status (2026)	ACTIVE — Annual cycle. Next cycle opens mid-2026.

Presidential Employment Stimulus Programme (PESP) — Arts & Culture

Organisation	National Arts Council (NAC) via Department of Sport, Arts and Culture (DSAC)
Amount / Value	Variable — project-based employment and stipend funding
Who Can Apply	Individual art practitioners and registered arts organisations in music, dance, craft, literature, visual arts, multidisciplinary arts, and musical theatre.
How to Apply	Download guidelines from nac.org.za or dsac.gov.za . Applications submitted via the NAC online portal.
Website	www.nac.org.za www.dsac.gov.za
Status (2026)	ACTIVE — PESP 6 cycle confirmed for 2025/2026 financial year.

SAMRO Music Creation Support Fund (MCSF)

Organisation	South African Music Rights Organisation (SAMRO)
Amount / Value	Micro-grants up to R25,000

Who Can Apply	SAMRO Full and Associate members who are composers — for the creation of new musical works.
How to Apply	Apply through SAMRO directly. Contact SAMRO Foundation: samrofoundation@samro.org.za or +27 (0)11 712 8417.
Website	www.samro.org.za/csi/the-samro-music-creation-support-fund
Status (2026)	ACTIVE — Rolling applications. SAMRO membership required.

SAMRO Foundation Bursary Programme

Organisation	SAMRO Foundation
Amount / Value	R11,000 per academic year (tuition fees)
Who Can Apply	Music students from second year onwards pursuing a diploma or degree at a recognised SA higher education institution (excludes first-year and doctoral students, and private colleges such as AFDA and City Varsity).
How to Apply	Complete the application form at samrofoundation.org.za/samro-musicBursaries.php . Contact: anriette.chorn@samro.org.za .
Website	www.samrofoundation.org.za
Status (2026)	ACTIVE — Annual intake.

National Lotteries Commission (NLC) — Arts, Culture & National Heritage Fund

Organisation	National Lotteries Commission (NLC)
Amount / Value	Variable — project-specific. Organisations may apply for significant sums where impact and reach is demonstrated.
Who Can Apply	Non-profit entities working for the public good in arts, culture, and heritage. Registered NPOs or PBOs required.
How to Apply	Download the Arts-Culture-and-National-Heritage-Guidelines and Application Manual from nlcsa.org.za . Submit online via the NLC funding portal.
Website	www.nlcsa.org.za
Status (2026)	ACTIVE — Ongoing. Multiple funding windows per year.

SAMRO Music Business Skills Programme (Bursary)

Organisation	South African Music Rights Organisation (SAMRO)
Amount / Value	Bursary towards approved music business and industry skills training
Who Can Apply	SAMRO Full and Associate members seeking to develop music business competencies.
How to Apply	Apply through SAMRO. Contact SAMRO Foundation for the current application window.
Website	www.samro.org.za
Status (2026)	ACTIVE — Periodic intake. Contact SAMRO Foundation for current availability.

□ PAN-AFRICAN & MULTI-COUNTRY PROGRAMMES

These programmes are open to artists across multiple African countries and represent some of the largest funding pools available on the continent. Most require partnerships, strong project proposals, and demonstrated artistic impact.

Music In Africa Foundation — Sound Connects Fund

Organisation	Music In Africa Foundation (MIAF)
Amount / Value	Grant and capacity-building support — amounts vary per project
Who Can Apply	Creative and cultural industry organisations in SADC countries: Angola, Botswana, eSwatini, Lesotho, Malawi, Mozambique, Namibia, Zambia, and Zimbabwe.
How to Apply	Apply via musicinafrica.net . Monitor the MIAF funding directory and open calls regularly.
Website	www.musicinafrica.net/directory-categories/funding
Status (2026)	ACTIVE — SADC-focused. Check musicinafrica.net for current call status.

British Council — Biennials Connect Grants

Organisation	British Council Sub-Saharan Africa
Amount / Value	Grants for travel, artwork production, networking, and professional development
Who Can Apply	Artists involved in biennial or festival exhibitions in eligible SSA countries: South Africa, Nigeria, Kenya, Ghana, Tanzania, Uganda, Rwanda, Zambia, Zimbabwe, Senegal, Ethiopia.
How to Apply	Apply via arts.britishcouncil.org . Projects must begin by February 2026 and conclude no later than February 2027.
Website	arts.britishcouncil.org britishcouncil.org.za
Status (2026)	ACTIVE — 2025/2026 cycle. Check britishcouncil.org for next open call.

British Council — Festival Connect Fund

Organisation	British Council Sub-Saharan Africa
Amount / Value	Up to £15,000 per project (three tiers: £5,000 / £10,000 / £15,000)
Who Can Apply	Festivals based in SSA (Uganda, Kenya, Nigeria, Ghana, Rwanda, South Africa, Tanzania, Zambia, Zimbabwe, Malawi) with collaborative proposals involving a UK partner festival.
How to Apply	Apply via britishcouncil.org . Proposals must promote cultural exchange, mobility, and community impact.
Website	www.britishcouncil.org/east-africa-arts/opportunities
Status (2026)	ACTIVE — Festival Connect Fund 2025 closed June 2025. Watch for 2026 cycle.

Africa No Filter — Project Grants

Organisation	Africa No Filter (ANF)
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Amount / Value	Variable — project grants for narrative change and creative storytelling
Who Can Apply	African artists, cultural practitioners, and media organisations working to challenge and shift stereotypical narratives about Africa through arts, culture, and media.
How to Apply	Apply via africanofilter.org/our-grants . ANF runs multiple grant cycles per year targeting different creative disciplines.
Website	www.africanofilter.org
Status (2026)	ACTIVE — Multiple cycles per year. Check website for current open calls.

Goethe-Institut — International Co-production Fund

Organisation	Goethe-Institut (German Cultural Institute)
Amount / Value	€15,000 to €30,000 per co-production
Who Can Apply	Artists and cultural organisations creating new or developing existing productions in music, theatre, dance, and performance — of high artistic standard with public impact. Must involve a German partner.
How to Apply	Apply via goethe.de . Deadline was 1 April 2026 for the current cycle — monitor for subsequent rounds.
Website	www.goethe.de
Status (2026)	ACTIVE — Bi-annual cycles. Next call expected late 2026.

German Federal Cultural Foundation — WAYS Programme

Organisation	German Federal Cultural Foundation (Kulturstiftung des Bundes)
Amount / Value	€27,000 (Initiation Fund) up to €1.6 million (Tandem Fund)
Who Can Apply	Cultural institutions in Germany seeking long-term artistic collaborations with partners in Africa, Latin America, and the Caribbean. African partners must be based in a WAYS-eligible country.
How to Apply	Three-stage programme: Initiation Fund, Fellows-at-Large Fund, Tandem Fund. Apply at kulturstiftung-bund.de . The October 2025 deadline has passed — monitor for next round.
Website	www.kulturstiftung-bund.de
Status (2026)	ACTIVE — Next application round expected 2026/2027.

Kuonyesha Art Fund

Organisation	Kuonyesha / CivSource Africa
Amount / Value	Project grants — amounts vary per cohort
Who Can Apply	Artists and collectives from Uganda, Kenya, Tanzania, Tunisia, Cameroon, Rwanda, and Ghana whose work uses art as a tool for justice, inclusion, memory, and community healing.
How to Apply	Apply via kuonyesha.civsourceafrica.com . Monitor for open cohort calls.
Website	kuonyesha.civsourceafrica.com
Status (2026)	ACTIVE — 2025 cohort announced. Watch for 2026 intake.

🇳🇬 NIGERIA

Nigeria's music industry — powered by Afrobeats and a rapidly professionalising business ecosystem — is increasingly supported by entrepreneurship-focused funds. While dedicated music-only grants are limited at the national level, the TEF's broad entrepreneurship mandate covers creative industry businesses, and Lagos State continues to develop its own cultural economy support structures.

Tony Elumelu Foundation Entrepreneurship Programme (TEF)

Organisation	Tony Elumelu Foundation
Amount / Value	USD \$5,000 non-refundable seed grant per entrepreneur + mentorship and business training
Who Can Apply	African entrepreneurs from all 54 African countries with innovative business ideas or existing businesses not older than 5 years — including creative and music industry businesses.
How to Apply	Apply at TEFConnect.com between 1 January and 1 March each year. The 2026 cycle closed March 2026.
Website	www.tonyelumelufoundation.org
Status (2026)	ACTIVE — Annual cycle. 2027 cycle opens January 2027.

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East African creative markets are served by a combination of international funds with regional mandates and local development programmes. The Braid Fund and Kuonyesha Art Fund are among the most active dedicated arts grant programmes for the region.

Braid Arts & Culture Fund

Organisation	Braid Fund
Amount / Value	Up to KES 750,000 (approx. R97,500) per grant
Who Can Apply	Arts and culture practitioners and projects in Kenya, Tanzania, and Uganda. Three grant categories: Completion (for projects already under way), Collaboration (cross-generational or cross-discipline), and Continuation (follow-on from previous Braid-funded projects).
How to Apply	Monitor ticahealth.org/resources/braidfund for open call announcements.
Website	www.ticahealth.org/resources/braidfund
Status (2026)	ACTIVE — 2025 grants issued. Watch for 2026 open call.

SENEGAL · CAMEROON · CÔTE D'IVOIRE · FRANCOPHONE

Francophone African artists benefit from a strong network of Institut français offices across the region, each of which runs localised cultural project calls. The Création Africa programme and PAIR residency offer the broadest Pan-Francophone African reach.

Institut français du Cameroun — Cultural Projects Call

Organisation	Institut français du Cameroun
Amount / Value	Project-based grants — amounts determined per application
Who Can Apply	Legally registered structures in Cameroon or France seeking to develop structural cultural projects. Eligible disciplines include music, street arts, literature, digital arts, heritage, and crafts.
How to Apply	Apply via ifcameroun.com. Applications for the 2025/2026 cycle closed 30 September 2025. Monitor for next cycle.
Website	www.ifcameroun.com
Status (2026)	ACTIVE — 2025/2026 cycle closed. Next call expected 2026.

Institut français — Création Africa Programme

Organisation	Institut français (French Institute)
Amount / Value	Variable — project and residency support
Who Can Apply	African artists and cultural operators in French-speaking Africa including Senegal, Côte d'Ivoire, Cameroon, and others. Focus on future-oriented sectors including digital creation, fashion, audiovisual, music, and immersive media.
How to Apply	Apply via institutfrancais.com. Monitor the open calls section for country-specific announcements.
Website	www.institutfrancais.com/en/programme/project-support/creation-africa
Status (2026)	ACTIVE — Ongoing programme with country-specific calls.

Institut français — PAIR (Programme for International Artists in Residence)

Organisation	Institut français
Amount / Value	20–30 projects supported per cycle — residency in Paris at Cité internationale des arts
Who Can Apply	African artists (and artists from other eligible regions) seeking an international residency in Paris. Open to multiple disciplines including music and performance.
How to Apply	Apply via institutfrancais.com/en/programme/project-support/pair. Projects run June 2026 – June 2027.
Website	www.institutfrancais.com/en/programme/project-support/pair
Status (2026)	ACTIVE — 2026/2027 cycle open. Check website for deadline.

HOW TO BUILD A WINNING GRANT APPLICATION

TIP	DETAIL
Align with the funder's mandate	Read the fund's objectives before writing a single word. Every grant has stated priorities — address them explicitly in your application. Do not submit a generic application.
Define measurable outcomes	Funders want to know what impact their money will have. State specific, measurable outcomes: number of songs recorded, shows performed, artists mentored, audiences reached, communities engaged.
Budget with precision	Every rand or dollar must be accounted for. Vague budgets raise red flags. Use the Album Budget template in this series to build a credible, itemised project budget.
Demonstrate track record	Even first-time grant applicants benefit from showing prior work — press coverage, performance history, social media reach, testimonials from industry partners.
Register before applying	Many SA funders require SAMRO membership, NPO registration, or a tax clearance certificate. Sort these administrative requirements before the application window opens — not after.
Follow up professionally	If you do not hear back within the stated timeline, one polite follow-up email is appropriate. Keep it concise. Build relationships with programme officers over time.
Unsuccessful? Ask for feedback	Most funders will provide written feedback on unsuccessful applications. Use it to improve your next submission. Persistence and iteration are key.
Combine funding streams	One grant rarely covers everything. Layer NAC funding with a SAMRO MCSF micro-grant, NLC support, and a crowdfunding campaign to reach your full project budget.

REGISTER BEFORE YOU APPLY — ESSENTIAL SA REGISTRATIONS

BODY / REGISTRATION	WHY IT MATTERS	WHERE TO REGISTER
SAMRO	Required for most SA music grants and to collect public performance royalties.	samro.org.za
CAPASSO	Required to collect mechanical royalties from streaming and physical reproduction.	capasso.co.za
SAMPRA	Required to collect neighbouring rights royalties as a performer or producer.	sampra.co.za
RISA (ISRC)	Get ISRC codes for your recordings — required for digital distribution and royalty tracking.	risa.org.za
CIPC (Companies)	Register your music business entity for formal contracting, banking, and grant eligibility.	cipc.co.za
NPO Registration (DSAC)	Required for many NAC and NLC grant applications if operating as a non-profit.	npo.gov.za
SARS Tax Clearance	Required by NAC, NLC, and most government-linked funders. Keep it up to date.	sars.gov.za
GS1 South Africa (Barcode / UPC)	Required for retail-distributed physical merchandise and CDs.	gs1za.org

DISCLAIMER: This guide reflects publicly available information about active grant programmes as of April 2026. Funding windows, amounts, and eligibility criteria change regularly. Always verify current details directly with each funding body's official website before applying. Nothing in this document constitutes financial or legal advice.